

Palm Tungsten W

The Tungsten W is a PDA-phone combination device with a full-fledged QWERTY keyboard. Running Palm OS 4.1.1, it has a full-sized stylus for operating the applications installed.

Measuring 4.8 x 3.1 x 0.7 inches and weighing 181 gm, the steel blue-coloured device is quite bulky. The fascia has the keyboard, the five-way navigator flanked by two application buttons on either side, and the power button. The top has a headset jack and an IR port, while a silo on the right houses the stylus.

The expansion card slot is on the right-hand side, contrary to other Palm handhelds, which house them on the top. The SIM card is inserted into a slot at the rear. The screen is covered by a leather flip cover that has a window to show who's calling.

Powered by the Motorola Dragonball VZ 33 MHz, the Tungsten W features 16 MB of internal memory, with 14.8 MB available to the user, and a 320 x 320 16-bit colour TFT screen. The tri-band GSM phone, with GPRS support, is useful for the global traveller.

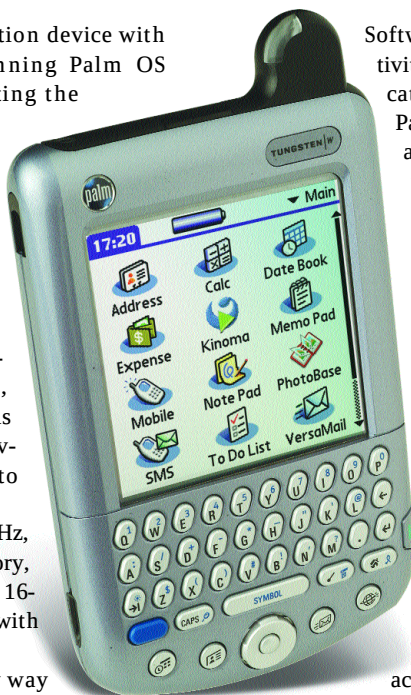
There is no integrated speaker, and the only way to use the phone is to connect the hands-free headset. A button on the headset lets you switch to the phone application at any point, and answer calls. Press and hold the button to hang up.

The device supports six profiles, and you can customise settings for each, including volume, vibrate mode and ringtones, and even divert calls to another number. The keyboard replaces the silkscreen area. The main keys are aligned in three rows. The fourth row has a blue function key, Shift/Caps Lock, spacebar, shortcut and Home keys. The Home key provides single press access to the 'home' applications. You can re-map each key as required.

The antenna's notification LED blinks green to show when the mobile is still within signal range, and red when it's not. The LED also indicates new messages, missed calls, alarms and battery status. In terms of connectivity, only IR is available—no Bluetooth. Application installation and PC synchronisation is accomplished through the bundled Palm Desktop

software and the USB cradle using the Palm Universal Connector.

The Tungsten W has SMS, Mobile Dialer and a VersaMail 2.0 e-mail client pre-installed, apart from standard applications such as Date Book, Calculator, Memo Pad, To Do, etc.; SIM Manager, Expense and Web-clipping support are installed on first sync. The



Software Essentials CD includes several productivity, entertainment and communications applications—Documents To Go, WorldMate, Jot, Palm Reader and ArcSoft PhotoBase. A call-management software called Mobile Dialer allows for caller ID, conference calls, call waiting, call forwarding, call logs, speed dialling, call profiles and dialling from your contacts list.

Performance-wise, the CPU is sluggish. There is a noticeable difference in responsiveness, especially when playing games and trying to switch between applications. The keyboard design and button placement is quite ergonomic, and a novice will have no problems using the device.

The pre-installed keyboard tutorial trains a new user to enter text, numbers and symbols. However, the keys are not backlit, so using the keyboard in the dark is a problem. The keyboard also lacks the directional arrows, and the five-way navigation key can't be used to scroll through text characters. As the Tungsten W lacks a Graffiti area, a

copy of CIC's Jot is included on the CD. Jot allows you to write directly on the screen, which takes some getting used to.

You can switch the screen backlight on or off by pressing and holding the power button for two seconds. The dialler application has large onscreen buttons, so you can dial, answer or reject calls with your fingers instead of the stylus. The lack of a physical switch to access silent mode is quite inconvenient.

As with other smartphones such as the Treo 180, SIM integration is poor. Though you can use the SIM Manager to read SIM contacts and copy them to the phone, or even dial directly off the SIM using the mobile application, reading the contacts takes a fair bit of time. You need to copy the SIM contacts to the device to be able to use telephony and messaging properly.

With the phone off, the internal 1500 mAh lithium polymer battery lasted a whopping 12 hours and 47 minutes. With the phone switched on, you get about three days with normal PDA and phone usage.

Lack of an integrated speaker and microphone makes the Tungsten W more suitable for those who want to use it mainly for its PDA functionality and wireless data access, and not as a replacement for a cellphone. The slow CPU and

lack of media playback features also need to be considered if you're thinking of acquiring a Tungsten W. However, with support for tri-band GSM, GPRS, an integrated keyboard and great battery life, the Tungsten W holds a lot of promise for globe-trotting executives.



The Mobile application on the Tungsten W lets you dial using your fingertips



Reading and editing documents using Documents To Go on the Tungsten W

+ Integrated keyboard, good battery life
- Slow CPU, lack of media playback
Price: Rs 21,999

Palm Tungsten W C+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶